

Death to the textarea

(and what to do about it)



Frédéric Harper

Senior Developer Relations Manager
TinyMCE

 fharper



NERD EARL

Photo by nygi on Unsplash

Lo siento, al contrario de lo
que dicen los rumores, no
hablo español.

Lo siento,
no hablo español.

It is 2026 and the default answer is still a textarea.

Every app eventually needs a place to write more than basic text.

**Your users press Cmd+B out of habit.
Nothing happens.**

They paste three paragraphs from Google Docs. All the formatting is messed up.

They want to collaborate. There is no way to do it.

**They do the back and forth dance
between ChatGPT and the content they
write...**

"We can just vibe code it."

It looks like a weekend. It turns into a permanent team.

**Why this is harder
than it looks**

It fails on four layers.

01

The browser

contenteditable, selection, undo, paste, IME

02

Accessibility

keyboard, focus, screen readers, no native control

03

Security

user-authored HTML, sanitization, XSS, forever

04

Features people expect

comments, suggestions, history, AI

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A rich text editor is not just a feature. It is a product.

And somebody has to maintain it after you ship.

What to do about it

Write a post

The form every app ships on day one.

HEADLINE

Everything I know about cat naps

STORY

Everything I know about cat naps

Ask three owners how long a cat sleeps and you will get three answers, all of them confident and none of them the same. So we ran a completely unscientific survey of the four cats in our building and wrote down what we saw.

What we found

Cat	Weight	Hours asleep	Favourite spot
Mochi	4.2 kg	16	The warm laptop
Biscuit	5.1 kg	14	A cardboard box
Olive	3.8 kg	17	The one sunny tile
Pepper	6.4 kg	13	Directly on the keyboard

Three things were true of every cat we watched:

The best sleeping spot is whichever one you were about to use

A closed door is an invitation, not an answer

Any surface becomes a bed once you put something important on it

If you want the long version, the

Publish

Write a post

The same form. The same field. The same submit.

HEADLINE

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STORY

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Everything I know about cat naps

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- A closed door is an invitation, not an answer
- Any surface becomes a bed once you put something important on it



Publish

The whole integration

```
<script  
  src="https://cdn.tiny.cloud/1/KEY/tinymce/8/tinymce.min.js">  
</script>
```

```
tinymce.init({  
  selector: 'textarea',  
  plugins: 'lists link image table code',  
  toolbar: 'undo redo | bold italic | bullist | link'  
});
```

The same form, the same field, the same submit.

The collaboration suite

01

Comments

threaded, anchored to a selection

01

Comments

threaded, anchored to a selection

02

Suggested edits

additions and deletions, accepted or rejected

01

Comments

threaded, anchored to a selection

02

Suggested edits

additions and deletions, accepted or rejected

03

Revision history

who changed what, and when

01

Comments

threaded, anchored to a selection

02

Suggested edits

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03

Revision history

who changed what, and when

04

Mentions

name someone inside the content

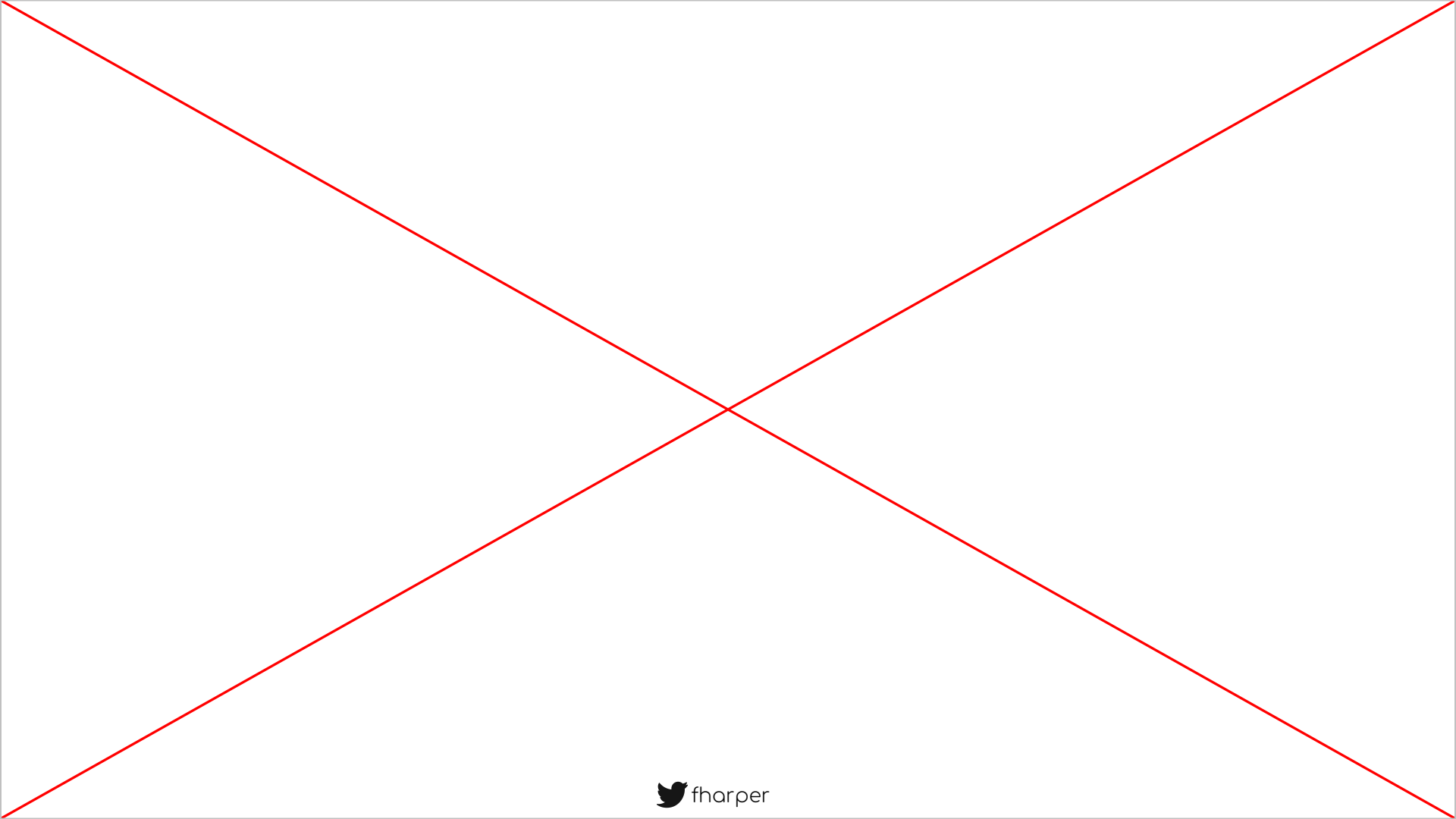
Four plugins, one init

```
tinymce.init({  
  plugins: [  
    'tinymcecomments', 'revisionhistory',  
    'suggestededits', 'mentions'  
  ]  
});
```

You connect it. You do not build it.

```
tinycomments_mode: 'embedded',  
user_id: 'fred',  
fetch_users: (ids) => Promise.resolve(USERS),  
revisionhistory_fetch: () => Promise.resolve(REVS),  
mentions_fetch: (query, done) => done(USERS)
```

The alternative is building comments, history, suggestions and mentions yourself.

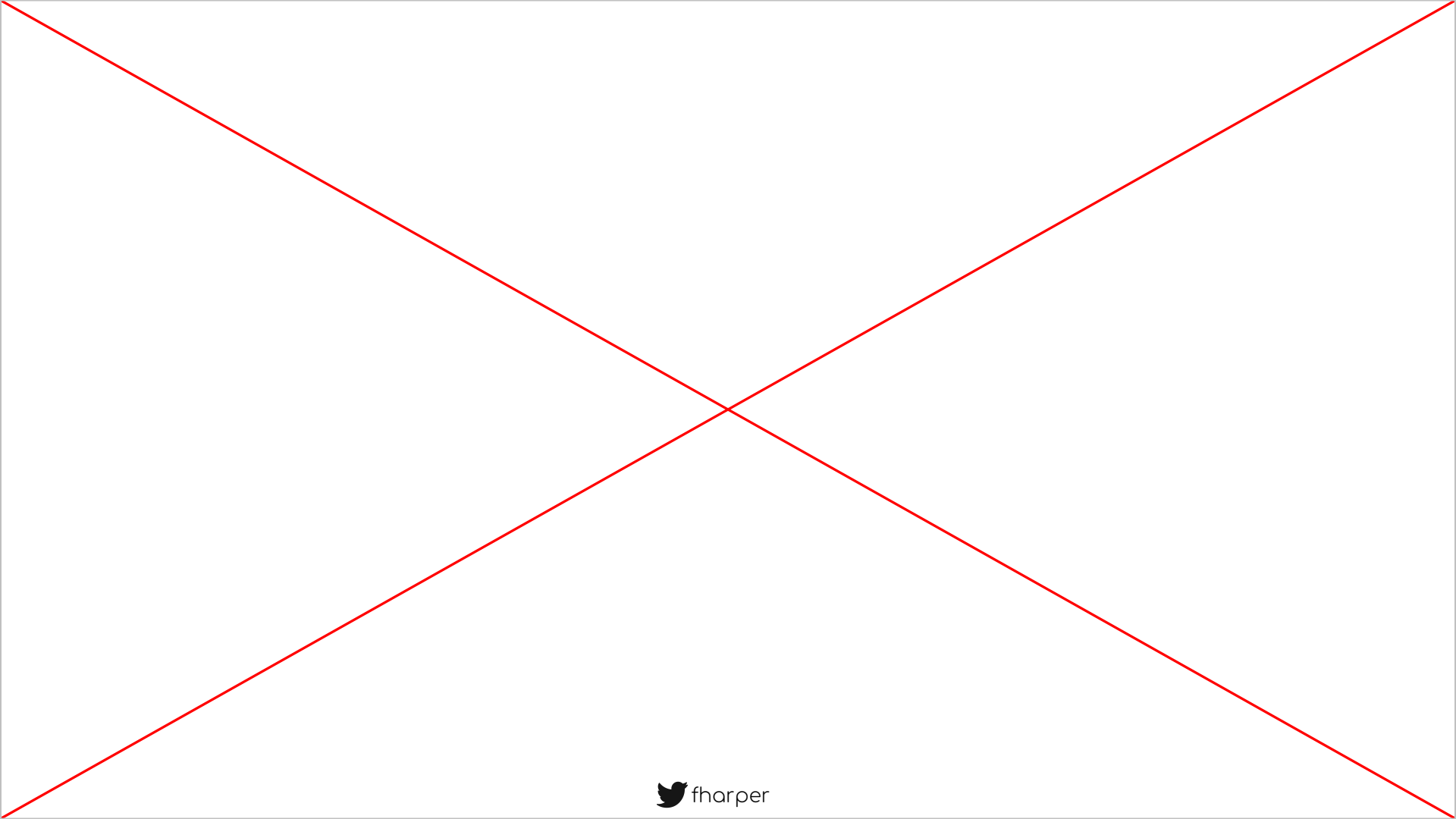


AI

AI in the editing surface

```
tinymce.init({  
  plugins: 'tinymceai',  
  toolbar: 'tinymceai-chat tinymceai-quickactions',  
  tinymceai_token_provider: () =>  
    fetch('/api/token').then((r) => r.json())  
});
```

The token is a JWT my backend signs. No model key ever reaches the browser.



The content is the context.

So I stop explaining what I am talking about.

The answer comes back formatted, in place.

No copy, no paste, no losing the structure on the way.

No more back & forth between tools.

In the end

Everything in those three demos was configuration.

A plugin list & a few callbacks.

What is left is your product.

Which is where you wanted to spend the time anyway.

Death to the textarea.

The people writing in your app deserve an actual tool.





Star Wars or Star Trek? Cast your vote and enter to win!

Stop by [our](#) booth to cast your vote
and [enter to win!](#)





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